

Hualalai

Appease the Volcano God

Design Document

Target Experience

High concept: You are the chiefs of four island nations living in the shadow of the Great Volcano God Hualalai. You must work together, trade resources and pray that your little fishing boats survive the treacherous ocean, so you can build totem sacrifices to appease your angry god. However, one of you is a wicked agent of chaos, bent on bringing on the God's destructive wrath.

Fellowship: The game is a four-player cooperative game with a hidden traitor. The honest players should feel the need to work together, conflicting with a distrust of each other. The traitor should feel the pleasure of secretly working within the coalition to undermine it.

Challenge: The intellectual challenge for the honest players is to strategise how to trade with one another to quickly generate the resources they need to build totems to win the game. This is complicated by the social challenge of working out which player is the traitor and work out how to prevent them from ruining their strategy.

The intellectual and social challenge for the traitor is to work out how to remain hidden and appear to be a helpful player while sowing seeds of distrust between other players and preventing them from achieving their goal.

Drama: The dramatic of the game should feel like a race against the odds, with an imminent threat constantly looming, but also with rare moments of relief. Ideally the game should come down to a last-minute victory or loss.

Fantasy: The game elements should support the fantasy of small frail island nations under the threat of a powerful and fickle god.

Core Gameplay

There are three overlapping core systems: the anger system, the resource trading mechanics and the prayer mechanics.

Anger System

The anger system serves as a simple timer for the game, building slowly towards disaster. There are two ways to get any relief from the relentless increase in anger:

1. The first totem sacrifice is a moment of small victory and gives the players some breathing room.
2. Sacrificing workers can hold back the anger by small amounts. This is tuned to be an expensive choice, intended as a last-ditch move, burning your own production in order to make time for a winning move.

This system is designed to provide the overall dramatic arc of the game. There is building tension about whether the players can successfully appease the god before the volcano erupts and everybody dies.

Resource Trading Mechanics

The core trading mechanics are designed to encourage players to trade for resources. This is achieved by:

- Creating an imbalance in supply.
- Creating an imbalance in demand.
- Keeping resources scarce.
- Creating interesting choices.

Supply: Players specialise in what kind of resources they produce by their choices in what huts they build. Each player starts with only 2 huts, so cannot produce all the necessary goods on their own. The worker placement rules reward having more workers on a single hut rather than spreading them out. The resources required to build new huts also favour specialisation, as less trade is needed to make extra huts of the same kind.

Demand: The prices for building huts, workers and totems require a variety of resources. If players want to diversify their production, they will need resources they are not already producing. Demand will vary depending on what players are building at any time.

Scarcity: Resource scarcity is maintained by the discard mechanic. Players cannot accumulate large amounts of resources, unless they spend extra on Storage, which is costly in terms of resources and construction time.

Prayer Mechanics

The prayer mechanics are the main source of uncertainty in the game. Any trade could potentially fail, whether by the randomness of the draw or by the secret undermining of the traitor.

When a boat is sent, 2 random prayer cards are played on it. There are equal numbers of Blessings and Curses in the prayer deck, so the chance of a boat sinking without any extra prayers played on it is 50%. This rate is deliberately high to encourage the spending of multiple prayer cards. When extra Blessings or Curses are played, the odds vary:

	0 Curses	1 Curse	2 Curses	3 Curses
0 Blessings	50%	75%	87.5%	100%
1 Blessing	25%	50%	75%	87.5%
2 Blessings	12.5%	25%	50%	75%
3 Blessings	0%	12.5%	25%	50%

This invites multiple prayers to be played on a boat, since a since blessing or curse won't always be effective in changing the odds. The distribution of prayer cards means the player will not always have enough prayers of their own to guarantee the successful arrival of their boat, and so need to rely on other players, whom they may not trust. The traitor can add curse cards to stop a trade from taking place but needs to do so without giving away their identity. To do this, they need to be able to cast suspicion either on the random draw (for up to 2 curses) or on other contributing players.

Note also that the value of an extra blessing/curse is not linear. Going from 0/0 to 1/0 increases your chances of success by 25%. Adding another blessing to 2/0 only increases by 12.5%.

Additional mechanics

Two other mechanics of note:

1. The passing of the Starter token. This mechanic is designed to reduce any advantage or disadvantage in being first or last in the play order. The passing rule means that the player who goes last in a round, then has the first move in the next round.
2. The setup mechanic of clockwise and anticlockwise selection is also designed to balance out the advantage (or disadvantage) of choosing starting huts first.

Interesting decisions

The main interesting decisions in the game are:

1. how to allocate their funds
2. which huts to build and staff
3. who to trade with
4. when to assign prayers to a voyage

Allocating funds:

This interesting choice arises from the overlap in the resource and prayer systems. The player has a choice of whether to spend their resources to build production (through resource huts and workers), to trade safely (through temples and prayers), or to win the game (through totems).

- **Balanced:** All three elements are needed to win, but their importance varies at different stages of the game, and are not easily comparable.
- **Informed:** The player can foresee the short-term outcomes of different choices, but the long-term strategy is unclear, due to the complexity of the game and the unreliability of the other players.
- **Consequential:** Running short of a needed resource for building or trade can stall the game and lose precious time. On the other hand, the players cannot spend forever building their resource base or they will run out of time before they can build their totems.
- **Situational:** The choice of how to allocate your funding is repeated each day of the game, but varies according to the shifting circumstances and the time remaining.

Building and staffing huts:

All four resources (shells, fronds, wood and prayers) are needed to win the game, but production rates mean self-sufficiency is difficult to achieve. In the early game, players need to decide whether to specialise in a particular resource or try to generate more than one. This depends on what other players are building

1. **Balanced:** All the resources are valuable. The main building resources are more-or-less comparable and the choice is mostly affected by what resources are abundant or scarce, and what the other players are producing (to diversify production but also have some redundancy rather than allow the traitor to have the monopoly on a needed resource). The decision of whether to build and staff temples, depends on the weather conditions and the abundance of blessings. It is difficult to calculate the relative value of resources vs prayers, creating a balanced choice.
2. **Informed:** The choice is informed by what resources the player needs to build huts or totems, and what resources are currently available (in the player's storage or via trade). There is uncertainty about what other players will produce and whether trade will be successful.
3. **Consequential:** Having the right resources is important to make progress in the game to build huts and totems.

4. **Situational:** The value of different resources shifts throughout the game depending on the players' current goals.

Trade:

Deciding which player to trade with is a matter of trust. One of the players is a traitor who is trying to undermine your effort to win and giving that player resources they need will make them more powerful. On the other hand, trade is necessary to win the game, as no player can generate sufficient resources on their own.

1. **Balanced:** Making a good trade can benefit both players. This is necessary to win the game. However, trading with the traitor is dangerous. They may renege on a deal, or become powerful enough to defeat you.
2. **Informed:** The choice is based primarily on the player's suspicions of who is the traitor. A clever traitor will attempt to disguise their status by giving the appearance of cooperation and casting doubt on others.
3. **Consequential:** Each player needs access to all three resources for building. If production is specialised, trade is necessary to allow this.
4. **Situational:** Who you want to trade with will depend on the distribution of resources and the apparent trustworthiness of players, which will shift throughout the game.

Prayers:

Assigning prayers to a journey is necessary to improve the odds of success. The value of adding a prayer depends on the number of prayers already assigned, and the trustworthiness of the other players.

1. **Balanced:** This is a risk-reward tradeoff. You can pay extra in order to guarantee success or you can take the risk of failure.
2. **Informed:** The number of cards already played (by random draw or from other players) can give you some assessment of the odds, but there is also uncertainty depending on whether other players are trustworthy.
3. **Consequential:** The number of prayers directly affects the probability of the trade succeeding or failing.
4. **Situational:** The choice is affected by the weather, the current anger level, and the number of prayer cards each player has available at that point of time in the game.

Adding Variety

The main source of variety in the game is the order of the Weather deck. This deck creates a meta-mechanic which changes the parameters of the prayer mechanics which in turn affects the player's ability and opportunities to trade. The deck has equal numbers of weather effect and No Change cards, so any weather effect is likely to stay in effect two turns on average, but possibly more or less.

Reflection

Overall the game works pretty well. Some notes:

- The mechanics suit the theme of the game very nicely.
- The combination of resource trading and trust / traitor mechanic brings together two common game systems in a way that is fairly original yet seems to work well.
- The resource system needs balancing. At the moment it is still too easy to fill your hand with resources and then have to discard them. There is a tension in the design between rewarding the player for specialisation and maintaining resource scarcity. Forced discard is not an elegant way to create scarcity. It would be nicer to tune the economy so that scarcity is dynamically created rather than forced.
- There is a major problem with the prayer cards. Honest players have no particular use for Curse cards as they rarely want a boat to sink, so 50% of the prayers they draw are useless to them. We need to find a solution which works well for both honest players and the traitor, without giving away who is who.